

# Your partner's caesarean

## What you actually do — Mark Harris

**First, the thing that matters most: a caesarean is a birth.** It counts. It's major surgery, yes — but it's the birth of your child, and you're still the parents in that room. Nobody gets to tell you otherwise. Including you.

## In the room

- She's awake — a spinal or an epidural. No pain, but pressure.
- A screen goes up. **Sit at her head. Hold her hand. Watch her face, not the screen.**
- It takes about forty-five minutes to an hour. The baby is usually out in the first few minutes.
- You'll be in scrubs. Look at her, not the lights.

## Your job

Everyone behind the screen has a job — the surgeon, the anaesthetist, the midwife. **Yours is the only one that matters to her.** You're not there for the operation. You're there for *her*. That's not nothing. That's the whole thing.

## If it wasn't planned

She may feel relief *and* disappointment, failure, grief for the birth she'd pictured. **All of it is allowed.** Don't tell her which feelings she's permitted. Lead with: **"This wasn't how you wanted it to go, was it?"** *Then* "but you did amazing." Say both — lead with the first.

## Ask for the facts

Under pressure, medics go vague. You ask for the specifics: *"What do you mean by dipping? What are the immediate steps?"* You're not being difficult. You're her witness.

## Skin to skin

The guidelines say she should have you in theatre and the baby on her chest as soon as it's safe. **That's the standard, not a favour. Say it early — before the surgery, to the right person.** If she can't hold the baby yet — shivering, or sick from the drugs — then it's you. The baby goes on your chest, skin to skin. That's not a consolation prize. That's the job.

## Ignore the label

"Gentle caesarean" is a name some units use for exactly this. Ask for the practice, not the word.

## After

Here's what catches men out: **the hard part isn't over for her.** She's had major surgery. **You're on your feet for weeks** — fetching things, lifting anything heavier than a baby, running the house without being asked. And watch her: if the birth sits heavily on her — anxiety, intrusive thoughts — that's not weakness, and it's not yours to fix. It's yours to notice, and to get her proper help.

## Before any of it is needed

Talk it through now, while there's no pressure: *"If it turns out we need a caesarean, what do you want me to make sure happens?"* **Birth plans are pencil, not ink. But the conversation matters more than the paper.**

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*From Men, Love & Birth — the new edition. There's a whole chapter on caesarean and instrumental birth.*